

International Sled Dog Racing Association (ISDRA)
Animal Welfare Policy
Feb 24, 2025

A. ANIMAL WELFARE POLICY:

Participants in any sanctioned event agree to abide by the following statement: There shall be no cruel, inhumane or abusive treatment of any dog, through deliberate action or inaction, through knowledge or ignorance, with or without implement, nor shall anyone deny a dog adequate care.

Examples of willful acts considered to be in violation include (but are not limited to):

1. Continuing to race a dog when it is injured, ill or too fatigued.
2. Maintaining dogs in obese or malnourished condition and asking them to compete in race situations competitively. Body conditioning scoring to be carried out by International Sled Dog Veterinary Medical Association Body Conditioning Scoring Chart. Dogs scoring a 1, 2, 8, or 9 in the International Sled Dog Association Body Conditioning Scoring Chart shall not be allowed to race per the International Sled Dog Racing Association guidelines.
3. Use of negative, physical means to discipline a dog during an event unless directly needed to break up or prevent a dog fight or prevent injury.
4. Failure to provide adequate shelter from the elements at a race site or during transportation to or from the race. All dog boxes used to provide shelter to the dogs shall be large enough to allow the dog to move comfortably. The boxes or trailers must allow for adequate ventilation. Dogs must be protected from both heat stress and cold stress. While it is understood that breed differences can result in a large range of acceptable temperatures for different sled dogs, the Race Marshall or Race Site Veterinarian if present, shall have final say in case of temperature related concerns. Dog boxes must be maintained in good working order to remain weather tight and to reduce the risk of escaped dogs.
5. Failure to provide adequate water or food. Racing dogs must have access to water immediately after completion of a race. Water access to be additionally provided when dogs are dropped from the travel boxes or crates. It is recommended that dogs be dropped every four to six hours during the day at race sites or when traveling and not stay in boxes or crates longer than 10 hours overnight. Any dogs displaying signs of dehydration (tacky or dry mucous membranes, increased skin turgor, capillary refill time prolonged over two seconds) to be assessed by a veterinarian immediately or be disqualified from the event.
6. To ensure health and prevent the spread of disease: core vaccinations as identified by the American Animal Hospital Association 2022 Canine Vaccination guidelines are recommended for participation in an ISDRA sanctioned race. It is up to the Race Giving Organization to enforce local vaccination requirements and practices. The American Animal Hospital Association (AAHA) identifies the following vaccinations as core for ALL dogs and states in their 2022 AAHA Canine Vaccination Guidelines: "All dogs should have the following core vaccines (unless there is a medical reason not to vaccinate): Distemper, Adenovirus, Parvovirus, +/- Parainfluenza, Rabies." Proof of current, required vaccines or titres to be required at race sites for all dogs over 16 weeks of age. Ideally all vaccination certificates and records for all racing dogs will be checked and audited, however it is understood that time and personnel constraints may prevent this. Therefore, it is recommended that a minimum of at least 6 random checks of vaccination certificates, proof

of vaccination or titres to be carried out by an onsite veterinarian, Race Marshall or Race Giving Organization designee at each race. The random checks will hopefully act as a deterrent to racers bringing unvaccinated dogs to the race site. Dogs to be found lacking proof of vaccination or titres will be disqualified and must leave the race site immediately. It is recommended that the names of musher's whose teams will be checked for the random vaccination certificate audit, be drawn and announced at the pre-race musher meeting with checks conducted prior to the end of the race.

7. It is the responsibility of the musher to adequately prepare their team both physically and behaviorally so that the dogs are ready to participate in the sport of mushing. Adequate training allows participating dogs to enjoy the event actively and enthusiastically. The Race Marshall has the authority to disqualify any team or team member that is not fully prepared.

All violations of this policy shall be brought to the Board of Directors for record. For violations not specifically covered in this policy, "Mush with P.R.I.D.E. Sled Dog Care Guidelines" shall be used as reference.

B. INJURY POLICY:

Any injury that occurs to a dog at a sanctioned event shall be reported to the Race Marshal, so that a log may be kept in order to eliminate further injuries. This report must not be used solely to find that any abuse has occurred. This policy shall also be in effect for dogs that expire while at a sanctioned event or because of their attendance at an event. The outcome of any Veterinary care should also be reported.

- This report shall contain:
 - The suspected injury.
 - The location the injury occurred (at the event).
 - Possible cause of the injury.
 - What first aid was applied.
 - Whether Veterinary services were sought.
 - Any findings from a Veterinary examination. (Either at the event or post event)

These reports will be kept in a file with the Race Marshal for the race season and then turned over to the Director of Timing. The Director of Timing will maintain a club record of injuries. The record will be kept on file with the hope that further injuries can be avoided.

C. REPORTING PROCEDURE:

Suspected infractions of any portion of this policy must be reported to the Race Marshal within one hour of the infraction. This report can be verbal but must then be followed by a written report within one half hour of the verbal report. NO action can be taken without a written report.

D. DEFINITIONS:

The following definitions shall be used for enforcement of this policy:

- ABUSE is an action that inflicts excessive or unnecessary pain or injury to a dog.
- DISCIPLINE is an action that causes a desired reaction. Discipline is the act that takes place at the instance of the action to be corrected (Not later).
- INJURY causes a dog pain or suffering in normal use or tenderness to the touch.

- ADEQUATE CARE is positive interaction, thus providing proper food, water, shelter, sanitary conditions and Veterinary medical attention needed to maintain a state of good health.

E. ENFORCEMENT PANEL:

The Race Marshal and The Board of Directors make up the enforcement panel. The Race Marshal shall be the key focal point for all violations. All reports of violations shall first be brought to the Race Marshal. The Race Marshal will be the chief investigator and will compile and bring the facts to the Board of Directors. The Enforcement Panel will assess all violations and institute all penalties.

F. PENALTIES:

Penalties for violations of this policy may include any of the following as deemed appropriate by the enforcement panel.

All parties involved in the report will be notified and action by the enforcement panel will be in a timely manner.

1. Acquittal: Written letter confirming acquittal of any violation.
2. Warnings: Written warnings will be issued for minor violations.
3. Disqualification/ Suspensions: Disqualification and/or suspensions could exclude the member from participation privileges in club events. A suspension will require a simple majority decision of the Enforcement Panel.
4. Dismissal: A dismissal will include a letter stating that membership and/or participation privileges have been revoked. A violation which leads to this action will also be reported to the Board of Directors of neighboring clubs. A dismissal will require a 2/3-majority decision of the Enforcement Panel. A member receiving three warnings or two disqualification / suspensions can be cause for dismissal.
5. Any person convicted in a court of law for animal abuse or neglect will be denied membership and racing privileges.